

ever



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CANAPÉ

Funnel cake with délice de Bourgogne, roasted celery root purée, trout roe and celery root leaves
Rutabaga custard bun with fried ginger
Coconut jelly with lime, mint, and meyer lemon zest

CAVIAR

Polanco Oscietra Grand Reserve caviar from Uruguay, candied hazelnut, hazelnut oil,
airy parsnip foam, caramelized parsnip pudding, and lemon balm

HAMACHI

Liquid nitrogen froze ribbons of Hamachi, Black rice pudding, crispy caramelized shallot,
African blue basil seeds and its leaves and purée, finger lime

BEETS

Roasted yellow beets, roasted candy striped beets, red beet purée, beet marshmallow, goat's milk foam, goat's milk meringue chip,
rye breadsticks, rye bread purée, whole grain crumble, lemon verbena, and oxalis

BREADS

with traditional butter with Hawaiian black lava salt and herbs butter blended with parsley, chives, chervil, dill, basil

SCALLOP

Pan-seared scallop from Nova Scotia Canada, coconut curry white sauce, sweet potato nest, sweet potato pavé layered with maple,
puffed seaweed, charred scallion oil, butternut squash purée, nasturtium leaves and pedals, and spinach purée

Paired bread: sweet curry milk bun

CHESTNUT

Aromatic smoke of cassia and cinnamon, chestnut and mascarpone filled pasta, cinnamon beurre monté,
torched mandarin, and fennel in the forms of puree, herb, and brunoise

Paired bread: fennel pollen and seed scone

PORK CHEEK

Red wine braised Berkshire pork cheek, candied cranberry and cranberry sauce, pistachio, chervil,
parsley root rolls and purée, white truffle crème caramel flan

Paired bread: Hawaiian black lava salt twisted pretzel

MIYAZAKI WAGYU

A slice of raw wagyu carpaccio on beef tendon cracker, A seared ribeye cut of A5 Miyazaki wagyu, paired with braised maitake mushroom,
dark sweet beef jus, Yukon gold potato ribbons, mustard seeds, potato puree, passionfruit sauce, licorice sauce

Paired bread: Porcini mushroom and Gruyère bagel

GRAPEFRUIT

Grapefruit sherbet with molasses and jalapeño meringue, tangerine lace, all underneath an EVER-logo shaped ginger tuile

CHOCOLATE

Chocolate brownie with compressed maple, sliced asian pear, lava cake bites,
spheres of caramel maple, encapsulated asian pear, topped with Hoja Santa

TINY SWEETS

Coconut waffle filled with tonka bean purée topped with kinome
Chocolate with cardamom and pomegranate



The chill rainy weather of Chicago fails to dampen our arduous anticipation for the reborn creation of chef Curtis – Ever restaurant, following the closure of his former three-Michelin star restaurant Grace. Ever exudes a temperament that distinctly separates itself from Grace. This innovative eatery is youthful, vibrant, and teeming with life. Its predominantly matte black interior acts as a modern "canvas" for the culinary artistry it hosts. Chef Curtis's ambition to present divine artistry and refined delicacies is evident, but does the food he presents meet our heightened expectations? It appears that Chef Curtis can't seem to shake off his preoccupation with excessively flashy and rustic American fare. Is his superficial redesign and transformation of American cuisine truly representative of contemporary fine dining? If this is the case, then regrettably, there's little space for Ever to mature. The restaurant's demise appears inevitable – a perpetual end.

Seated around an oval table, we are promptly served with the amuse bouche. Three types of remarkably unattractive morsels are nestled atop bulbous roots, resting on a cheaply made matte black plate that oozes an air of inferiority. Yes, Core by Clara Smyth employs almost a botanic garden to present their amuse bouche; Yes, Azurmendi also utilizes trees and natural creatures and a lunch picnic box for welcoming bites. It's worth noting that Core's meticulously crafted miniature arboretum radiates elegant beauty. In the case of Azurmendi, the restaurant's overarching theme of greenery, nature, and eco-friendliness justifies its use of wood and natural components, resulting in a harmonious and aesthetically pleasing environment. Additionally, both restaurants excel in allowing the small bites to remain the central focus, clearly visible and contrasting against their backgrounds, even when partially concealed. Regrettably, none of these merits are achieved at Ever. Aesthetic missteps become glaringly apparent, particularly with the presence of bulb roots. This presentation not only evokes a sense of peasant-like rusticity but also starkly contrasts with the restaurant's supposed high-end contemporary artistic ambiance, resulting in an unseemly departure from its intended character. The poor design choices extend to the food itself. The color palette of the three bites is limited to yellow, white, and green, rendering them not only visually monotonous and displeasing but also creating an illusion that almost makes the bites appear invisible. In terms of texture, the bites embody some of the most mundane and banal characteristics, giving rise to the sensation that we are partaking in a disguised recreation of the most subpar deli snacks.

The first bite features a funnel cake with *délice de Bourgogne*, roasted celery root purée, trout roe, and celery root leaves. The funnel cake is so casually made into a poor shape that soon distinguishes our anticipation. What is Trout Roe doing here? I have to ask. Its flavor is almost undetectable, and so is its popping texture. Same problem applies to the *délice de Bourgogne*. It seems that this funnel cake is no better than a sample bite of a milky cracker with some cream on top at a Whole Foods market. Moving on to the rutabaga custard bun with fried ginger. While I enjoy the texture of the airy bun and the idea of combining ginger with rutabaga, it is, unfortunately, hard to taste either the rutabaga or the fried ginger, as the custard flavor dominates the bun. The final bite seems to be irrelevant to its companions, a coconut jelly with lime, mint, and Meyer lemon zest sounds and tastes both tropical and summertime, which not only sounds improper for the winter weather but also immediately transports us from the fields and rural garden to a sunny tropical beach without much clue.

A funny interlude happens at this time, further enhancing the bizarre temperament of Ever. As I enter the powder room, an all-matte-black interior unfolds just as expected. While the ambiance captivates, rendering our time there both mysterious and delightful, the radio broadcast over the speakers proves to be somewhat irksome. It features two men engaging in lewd and inappropriate conversation about hooking up women, a stark contrast to the refined setting.

Returning to the dining table, the first course promptly arrives on the table. Ever seems keen on showcasing caviar right in the front. The centerpiece of the bowl plate is the Polanco Oscietra Grand Reserve caviar from Uruguay. While Uruguayan caviar appears to be a specialty, regrettably, the petite portion served prevents me from fully savoring its taste. The caviar rests delicately atop a caramelized parsnip pudding, accompanied by three lemon balm leaves. A candied hazelnut garnishes the ensemble, with a final touch of airy parsnip foam and hazelnut oil to complete the medley. Judging by the portion size of this dish, it appears the chef intends for us to experience its entirety in a single bite, a task challenging if one aims to appreciate each component individually. Nevertheless, the culinary journey this dish offers is exceptional. The oceanic umami and vibrant texture of the caviar harmonize flawlessly with the caramelized parsnip pudding. Not only does the pudding boast a luxurious creamy texture, but it also marries its distinct earthy flavor and intensified sweetness with the caviar. Enhanced by the airy parsnip foam and the nutty aroma of hazelnut oil, the dish unfolds as a multi-layered and textured masterpiece. The addition of lemon balm, exuding a citrusy herbal aroma, imbues the medley with freshness and a sunny disposition, while the candied hazelnut introduces a rich and colorful sweetness. However, the candied hazelnut's size impedes proper enjoyment alongside other components; perhaps a finer outcome could be achieved by slicing it into smaller pieces and scattering them atop the dish. The presentation also lacks refinement; the silly installation of three pieces of lemon balm appears somewhat whimsical, reminiscent of the most mundane dessert that garnishes mint leaves on top. Additionally, the arrangement of the caramelized parsnip pudding lacks a certain aesthetic appeal.

The following dish presents a fish appetizer featuring Hamachi, hinting at Japanese and Vietnamese influence. Within the bowl, ribbons of hamachi fish take the spotlight. Frozen with liquid nitrogen, the Hamachi ribbons are accompanied by black rice pudding, crispy caramelized shallots, finger lime, and African blue basil in three forms: seeds, leaves, and purée. With its Japanese name, one might expect to savor the hamachi either raw as sashimi or prepared in a refined cooking style, both methods intended to highlight the fish's essence and flavor profile. However, here, the fish undergoes a unique frozen process, which, while intriguing, ultimately compromises the fish's flavor. The black rice pudding almost resembles a dessert, with its unique sweetness and glutinous texture. Combined with the hamachi ribbons and crispy caramelized shallots, it evokes a rustic Vietnamese approach reminiscent of consuming overnight cold fish in a bowl of congee. While undoubtedly an avant-garde interpretation and bold endeavor, the necessity and coherence of such a combination warrant scrutiny. The African blue basil, a hybrid of camphor basil and dark opal basil, possesses a bolder flavor profile than other basil varieties due to its strong camphor undertones and spicy basil flavor.

While its refreshing icy herbal camphor aroma may seem suitable with the frozen hamachi, its inclusion further confounds the medley as it does not harmonize well with the black rice pudding or the caramelized shallots. It is worth mentioning that such a frozen technique isn't new to the culinary world, as the famous three-Michelin-starred restaurant Arzak from San Sebastián has a famous dish that freezes wagyu with liquid nitrogen from decades ago. Unfortunately, I haven't had the chance to visit Arzak and thus I reserve my judgment for this frozen Hamachi dish at Ever.





A vegetarian course then follows, presenting an array of various kinds of beets that undergo a diverse range of preparations. The plate features golden beets and candy-striped beets roasted to perfection, dehydrated and rehydrated red beet transformed into a velvety purée, and beet marshmallows crafted with beet sugar and egg whites then delicately dusted with red beet powder. Acting as a unifying element, goat milk manifests as a substantial sphere of creamy foam, complemented by goat milk meringue chips scattered amongst the beets. To complete the ensemble, an assortment of grains and wheat creations are thoughtfully arranged: rye bread purée, housemade rye tuiles that are essentially housemade rye breadsticks, and whole grain crumbles comprising fried bulgur wheat, amaranth, buckwheat, and wild rice. Lemon verbena and oxalis garnishes add a final touch of freshness and gracefulness to finish the dish.

The diverse range of textures plays an essential role here, sending nuanced layers of sensations to the diner's palate. In one plate, we experience the condensed yet juicy texture from the beets, the spongy marshmallow, the airy crispy meringue, the creamy velvety foam, the gel-like purées, and finally the rustic crunchy grains. It is these intricate textures that bestow the dish with vitality, not only are they individually enjoyable, but they also complement each other when combined. Compared to its miscellaneous textures, this dish presents a relatively uniform flavor profile that centers around beets and goat milk, which maintains coherence and logic amid its complexity. Another highlight of this dish is the contrast between the fresh, primal flavor of goat milk and the intense depth resulting from the sophisticated processing of beetroot. However, this dish also signals a certain threshold; for diners wary of the distinctive flavors of beetroot and goat milk, it could undoubtedly be disastrous. While I enjoy the flavors and textures, I must raise a significant concern: it seems to lack the refinement often associated with fine dining. Many elements, particularly those incorporating grains and wheat, unintentionally exude a coarse and rustic quality, hinting at a gauche American influence.



The beet course concludes the first part of the dinner, and as we move on to the main dishes, we are first introduced to the bread selections. A unique concept at Ever is its bread pairing: each of the four main courses is complemented by a distinct type of bread, accompanied by two varieties of butter. One is a classic yellow butter infused with Hawaiian black lava salt, while the other is an herb-infused blend featuring parsley, chives, chervil, dill, and basil.

The first main course showcases a Canadian scallop sourced from Nova Scotia, skillfully pan-seared to attain perfection. The scallop exudes an oceanic umami and a mesmerizing concentrated sweetness, harmonized by the natural sweetness of sweet potato, intricately fashioned into a nest and a pavé interlaced with maple syrup. Delicately puffed seaweed adds both visual allure and an additional layer of oceanic earthiness and unique umami to the ensemble, while nasturtium leaves and petals lend vibrant herbal and floral accents. Complementing this symphony of flavors is an array of sauces: a coconut curry white sauce and spinach purée serve as the primary components, augmented by accents of butternut squash purée and charred scallion oil, resulting in a kaleidoscope of hues and multidimensional tastes.

A sweet curry milk bun is served to pair with the scallop dish. While the presence of curry flavor may serve as a link between the bread and the scallop dish, it appears to be a less optimal choice. In this scallop dish, a more predominant element like the sweet potato could be a more suitable flavor choice for the bread.

An aromatic smoke of cassia and cinnamon wafts from the dinnerware when the next course graces our table.

Inside the bowl rests a flower-shaped long pasta filled with chestnut paste and mascarpone cheese, while a cinnamon beurre monté sauce underlays beneath the pasta, echoing the charming ethereal cinnamon smoke with a velvety creamy substance. A segment of mandarin is torched and adorned aside, together with various parts and executions of fennel in the forms of purée, brunoise, and its herbs. This course celebrates the harmony of chestnuts and pasta. Interestingly, while chestnut is not commonly used as a filling for ravioli, it shares similarities with the more prevalent butternut squash. Both ingredients boast a rich, natural sweetness that adds depth to dishes and pairs harmoniously with mascarpone cheese. Additionally, their starchy and pasty textures lend themselves perfectly to creating a velvety creamy filling. Moreover, both chestnut and butternut squash showcase the essence of celebrating colder weather and complement cinnamon flavors splendidly. Ever's ingenuity thus deserves commendation for crafting a unique pasta dish that leaves a lasting impression while still offering a somewhat familiar flavor profile.

Although the specific variety of pasta remains unnamed, some argue that it is a contemporary tortellini while some state that it is a stuffed tagliatelle, its contemporary disguise can't hide its nature form that closely resembles ravioli. The presence of mascarpone further solidifies this association, as it is a traditional filling for ravioli. It appears that ravioli, or any other stuffed pasta such as agnolotti, gnocchi, or tortellini, have become popular on modern American fine dining tasting menus. Comparable pasta creations can be found at renowned establishments like Melisse, Orsa & Winston, and Manzke in Los Angeles.

To complement the pasta dish, a fennel scone is served. Utilizing both fennel pollen and seeds, this bread exudes a distinctive earthy and herbal aroma that harmonizes with the other fennel components of the pasta. However, since the scone itself is a rather dense pastry, pairing it with pasta tends to be overwhelming. Both being carbohydrates, it seems somewhat unnecessary to accompany pasta with scone at the same time.

The following dish pays homage to traditional French cuisine. At the heart of the plate rests a small piece of Berkshire pork cheek braised in red wine, served alongside a slice of white truffle crème caramel flan. Continuing in the French culinary tradition, elements of the parsley family play a prominent role, with fresh chervil, parsley root rolls, and a quenelle of parsley root purée adding their distinctive flavors to the ensemble. Candied cranberry and cranberry sauce further join the showcase, accenting the dish with an additional layer of tart acidity and fruity aroma, echoing the red wine saturated into the pork cheek. Lastly, pistachios are also presented on the plate.

Red wine braising may be a common cooking method today, but whenever one sees it, it always reminds people of boeuf bourguignon. The outcome here is similar to a traditional boeuf bourguignon, a piece of pork cheek exhibiting depths of red wine flavor and a heavenly tender texture. A slice of white truffle crème caramel flan is served alongside, balancing the richness of the pork and enhancing the overall flavor profile. Though lacking a promising truffle aroma, the delicate custard flan showcases a delicate flavor that enhances the flavors of the pork cheek without overpowering them. The mild sweetness and subtle hints of vanilla and caramel in the flan complement the savory notes and the mild red wine acidity, elevating the overall flavor profile of the dish. Moreover, the rich cut of pork benefits from the creamy texture and subtle sweetness of the flan as it adds a contrasting element that balances out the savory flavors of the meat, creating a more harmonious overall taste experience.

Herb is one of the cornerstones of French cuisine. Here, the chef opts to replace traditional parsley leaf with its cousin chervil. Known for its subtle flavor with delicate hints of licorice or anise, chervil adds a nuanced depth without overpowering the palate. Additionally, the root of the parsley is employed in both shaved and puréed forms, imparting a distinctive yet unified flavor reminiscent of a blend between celery root, carrots, and parsnips through the contrasting textures of crispy, firm shaves, and creamy velvety purée, creating a dynamic culinary experience.

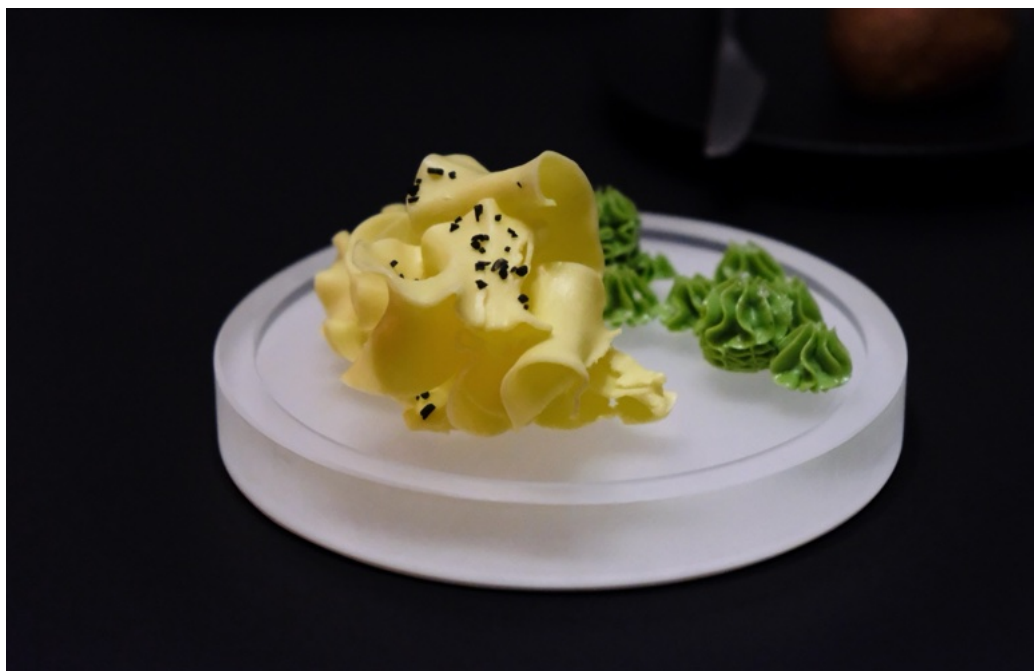
One drawback of the dish is the addition of pistachio, which does not provide enough flavor to sublimiate the tasting experience but rather provides an unpleasant soggy texture. Besides all these accompaniments, a Hawaiian black lava salt twisted pretzel is further served as the bread pairing for this course.





Ensuing the pork cheek, the final savory course makes its grand entrance. On a large plate presents Miyazaki wagyu in two parts, one being a seared ribeye cut of A5 Miyazaki wagyu paired with braised maitake mushroom, and the other being a slice of raw wagyu carpaccio on a puffed cracker made with beef tendon. A medley of dark sweet beef jus, Yukon gold potato ribbons, mustard seeds, potato purée, passionfruit sauce, and licorice sauce further joins in, enriching the beef duo with shades of flavors.

As much as I appreciate the idea of presenting a contrasting duo of beef, the combo fails to impress in the same way as chefs nowadays like to present birds with different parts. Although the duo shows an innate connection, the two parts work in different directions and cannot figure out a way to meet at the joint. On the one hand, we have a perfectly done seared wagyu beef. The ribeye cut sings in perfect harmony with the braised maitake, forming a classic French haute cuisine main dish on its own with the help of potato purée and beef jus. On the other hand, we see a beef tendon cracker with a raw slice of wagyu carpaccio on it. Leaving aside how microscopic the carpaccio is, the beef tendon itself acts like a street food snack. A profound beef umami is indeed predominating the cracker, yet the texture of the cracker suggests that the bite tastes cheap and unrefined by its nature. The petit slice of wagyu carpaccio functions not as a natural treasure that is to be appreciated but rather as an assistive richness provider like a piece of butter. As much as I wish to see the duo as a unity, I can never shed the feeling that I'm digesting a rare cut of beef in a cheap fast food restaurant.



The accompaniments also bring in a touch of weirdness. While the majority focuses on passing on the classical French cuisine flavor, the microscopic dot of licorice sauce seems unrelated. Given its size, one can never manage to apply it to each part of the dish, maybe it is even impossible to taste the licorice at all. Along with the dish is a bagel bread with Porcini mushroom and Gruyère cheese. The appliance of porcini mushroom enhances the fungal earthy aroma in a similar yet altered manner to that of the maitake mushroom, while the Gruyère cheese adds a creamy tangy cheese aroma to the bagel, giving the bread a certain weight that could counter the main dish.

Finishing the beef dish, the savory part of the tasting menu come to a closure, so is the bread pairing. In general, I find the bread courses unnecessary and somewhat redundant. Flavored breads are not rare indeed, yet the idea of creating a flavor connection between a dish and a bread works different from wine pairing. Breads are not enjoyed simultaneously with the course, and such behavior creates a natural barrier for the anticipated flavor connection. If breads are enjoyed with the course it would be like eating a stuffed bread or simply a dinner course with an added bread component, which could significantly modify the texture and the flavor profile of the whole dish as the bread carries such a weighty substance.

Two meat dishes with profound depths are followed not by a palate cleanser but rather directly a dessert highlighting grapefruit. In a J.L. Coquet hemisphere bubble bowl rests a quenelle of grapefruit sherbet adorned with molasses, jalapeño meringue, tangerine lace, and a touch of herbs. The bowl is covered with ginger tuile made into the shape of the restaurant logo, showcasing a contemporary aesthetic. While the grapefruit sherbet on its own can be refreshing and light in texture and serves perfectly as a palate cleanser, the rest of the composition regrettably adds a tremendous amount of weight onto the palate. The ethereal sherbet is covered by the rather thick and viscous lace, and the jalapeño meringue, though light in texture, sends waves of spicy kicks to the tongue. To make it worse, the ginger tuile, heavy and harsh like a gingerbread house, further adds tons of weight, dry texture, and dense dark sweetness to the small portion, completely ruining the equilibrium.

The next chocolate dessert further punishes our palate by epitomizing the fatal flaws often criticized in American desserts. The exquisite French pastries and desserts, especially refined by Japanese culinary aesthetics, exhibit delicate textures and perfect flavor balance. Such dessert aesthetic seems to have been entirely forgotten in the United States. American desserts, represented by New York cheesecake and various pies, often disregard texture and sweetness in their pairings, instead piling on extremely heavy elements endlessly, resulting in rough textures, overly sweet, heavy, greasy, and excessively calorific treats.

At the base of this bowl rests a decadent chocolate brownie adorned with compressed maple and sliced Asian pear, formed into a medallion. On top of the medallion are spheres of lava cake bites, caramel maple, and encapsulated Asian pear. A final flourish of Hoja Santa, also recognized as Mexican peppermint, adds a nuanced touch to this medley. While the brownie may evoke good memories of daily indulgence, its feasibility for fine dining dessert presentation is questionable, particularly when its proportions exceed a single bite. Here, all I get from the brownie is its heavy massive density, imparting an awful sense of burden rather than culinary delight. Both its overly dense texture and excessively saccharine sweetness overwhelm the palate, leaving little room for appreciation of other subtler flavors. On a fine dining table, such a sensation will be amplified, making digesting this medallion of brownie no different from biting a whole brick of chocolate.

The lava cake bites on top introduce even worse memories by adding more loads of burden to the palate. Lava cake, notorious for its intense richness and sweetness, compounds the already weighty experience. It's similar to layering cheese fondue onto an already dense potato puree saturated with ample amounts of butter, resulting in an overwhelming amalgamation of heaviness. While I understand the idea of adding nuances of textures and flavors of a single ingredient, which for here is chocolate, may bring finesse to the final composition, such execution only works when every component is at a piano dynamic, similar to Debussy's ethereal music. When everything is shouting fortissimo, such layering can only bring a terrible sensation that lingers forever. There is no need for further discussion on the maple apple spheres, which by no surprise add another layer of weight to our tongues. While the Asian pear may sound refreshing, its excessively condensed texture and sweetness are yet another burden. At last, the peppermint is just too weak to save the whole bowl, there is just no way to conquer an empire with just one bullet.





To finish up the meal, a duo of tiny sweets is presented. On a meticulously shaped thing, we find a coconut waffle filled with tonka bean purée topped with kinome, and a chocolate with cardamom and pomegranate, both to be yet another attempt at mediocrity. Enough talking about food, let us dig into the service part which to me is the major failure of this experience. Imagine stepping into such a refined restaurant, anticipated and excited, only to find yourself caught in a whirlwind of mishaps and confusion. While the food is nothing less than a major component to blame, their service is an even bigger problem. First off, let's talk about the waitstaff. When introducing the dishes, they seemed like they were reading from a script, robotically reciting menu explanations without much basic human emotions. When I asked for more details, they seemed lost and did no further explanation, repeating the same lines like broken records. Then there's the mess menu printed out for us at the end of the meal. Outdated dishes were still listed, how can such a mistake be tolerated on a menu that is supposed to be a good memory for us to keep for the special, one-of-a-kind dinner we had when the menu listed the meal someone else enjoyed days ago? To make it worse, they simply listed the city name Miyazaki for the beef course without clarifying whether it was Wagyu beef. This simply proves that they have no basic understanding of such ingredients, which is no different from recognizing "pizza" as the name of Antonio's pizza shop. And let's not forget about basic things like catering to left-handed guests. Despite my guest's attempts to rearrange my utensils for easier use, the staff didn't seem to notice or care. Worst of all, the bill came even before we finished the meal as if they were rushing us to finish and go. After the meal, I tried to reach out via email with some questions and feedback. But guess what? It took forever to get a response, and when I finally did, it was curt and unhelpful. Plus, they promised a follow-up in two weeks which turned into a month of silence until I had to remind them dozens of times. It is beyond imagination that the chef, who once created a legendary three-Michelin-star establishment, returned with such a mess. I could only hope that my next dining adventure is smoother and less like a comedy of errors.